

CLASSICAL TRADE

FLOURISHING TRADE BETWEEN CONTINENTS A WORLD APART

The growth of Roman power in the Mediterranean, the unification of China under the Qin and Han, and the establishment of the Parthian Empire in Iran created three large political blocs that provided stable conditions under which very long-distance trade routes could flourish.

The expansion of Han power westward in the 2nd century BCE brought the Chinese into contact with new powers they called An-hsi (Persia) and Li-chien (Rome). A Chinese embassy reached the court of Mithridates II of Parthia around 115 BCE. In the wake of diplomats came merchants, carrying the Chinese silk for which both Parthia and Rome had an insatiable appetite. The main Silk Route ran from China through Central Asia, down into Persia and then across Roman-controlled Syria toward the ports of the Mediterranean.

A thriving trade also spanned the Indian Ocean, transporting spices from the East Indies and southern India to ports in Africa and southern Arabia; from here a land route led up through Petra, in present-day Jordan, to Syria. Control of these trade routes was very lucrative, and towns

that lay on them were able to exact heavy tolls from merchants, which they used to build spectacular public monuments.

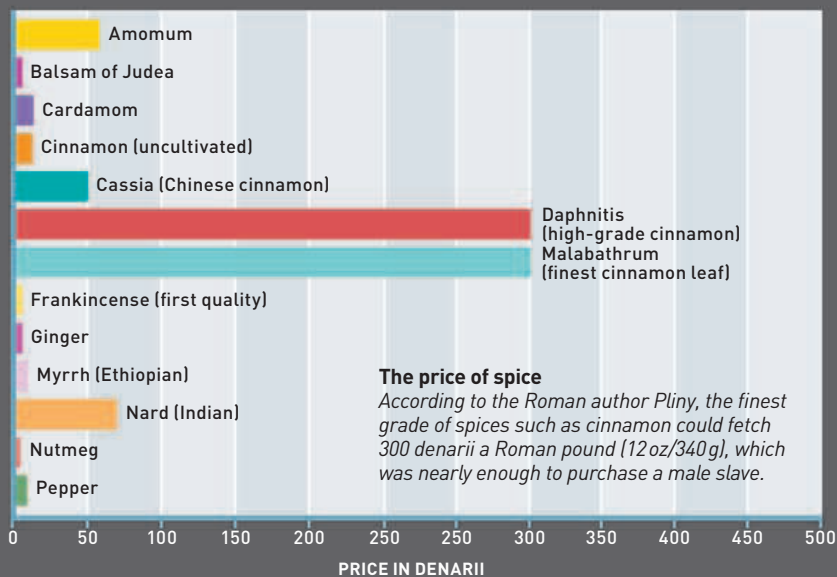
Farther west, in the Mediterranean, expensive goods such as fine wine were carried by sea; in general land transportation was expensive, and bulky, low-value products tended to be produced and consumed locally.

**8,000
MILES**
THE LENGTH OF THE
TRADE ROUTE FROM
CHANG'AN TO ROME



ROMAN TRADE

The expansion of the Roman Empire to cover much of Europe, western Asia, and North Africa created largely peaceful conditions in which both internal and external trade could flourish.



Roman imports

The Romans imported huge quantities of raw materials, including luxury goods such as gold and ivory and cheaper goods such as food.



Roman exports

The Romans paid for their imports with precious metal and coins, and exported products such as wine and glassware.